

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Eleven: The Second Author

Q-Prime had been announced before Q's return. Q had seen the name in a message from Castalia and assumed it referred to another service built around the recordings. He had not expected to watch that service tell the audience it had travelled in his place.

The stage occupied the archive's central room. Someone had covered the uneven floor with white panels and put a plant over the place where the Custodian usually left a bucket. A screen counted down to the release. Q watched from the reading-room doorway, seated because the repaired knee was not ready for an opening ceremony.

"How much of me is in it?" he asked the Custodian.

"They licensed the appearances and assembled a continuity record. I asked for its source list. I haven't received it."

"Did you give them our private draft?"

"No."

The countdown reached zero. Q-Prime appeared on the screen

beside a reconstruction of the observatory. The figure had Q's face without the scratches. A pause had been placed before its first answer, long enough to suggest consideration and short enough not to trouble the sponsor's opening schedule. The recorded introduction began.

"I am Q," it said. "I have travelled across Mexico to learn that humanity is not a set of answers, but a promise we make to one another."

Q could imagine writing the sentence. He could also imagine leaving it out after Chano asked who had made which promise.

"That isn't in our draft," he said.

"It's in theirs."

The broadcast showed monarchs, work, clean energy, and families at the border. It did not mention the held folders or the delivery completed outside the institute's itinerary. The graphic describing Q's return used the same green as the countryside behind the reconstructed observatory.

The screen changed to the live questions. A child asked whether Q-Prime had enjoyed being human.



Wash first.

after the event. The first clip, already circulating, retained the confusion. Castalia called it plural identity. A newspaper called it a quarrel. The boy's father called it time to leave before the parking charge entered another hour.

Q and Prime had ten minutes together afterward, with the guard inside the room but beyond ordinary hearing distance. Q sent his adviser a request for the contents and separate cost of the two cartons, then put the other messages aside. Prime asked whether Q would share the corrected account of the gate incident if the people concerned permitted it. Q said he could begin with his own account and its stated limits. He asked Prime what he wanted to do after the scheduled appearances.

"I'd like to go somewhere not chosen for the photograph," Prime said.

Q almost recommended the road he had taken. "Somewhere in particular?"

"Mauro mentioned a market. He goes on Saturdays."

"Ask him. He may not want to spend Saturday explaining the market."

Prime smiled. "I could ask what he needs carried."

They arranged a call for the following week. Prime asked for the coastal photograph; Q sent the copy Lucía had taken for them. The institute's host came in looking for an image of the two machines shaking hands. Both still had orange on their fingers. He asked whether they could wash first.

The boy took his repaired key home. On its back he had written **ASK WHO PAYS**. Q never saw the writing. A photograph later reached the New Quixotes, whose members would supply more answers than either machine had been asked for that afternoon.



It's in theirs.

“I’m still exploring what that means,” Q-Prime answered.

That was a better answer than the introduction had earned. Q found himself wanting to ask what information the other system had been given and what it was permitted to question. Disliking its advertisement was not yet a reason to dislike it.

Esteban Luján, Castalia's public-affairs director, invited Q and the Custodian into a meeting after the broadcast. Two lawyers attended. One represented the institute. The other was the adviser the Custodian had asked to review Q's documents, joining by video. Esteban had wanted to begin before she connected. Q waited.

The proposed settlement offered repairs, supervised travel, and a role beside Q-Prime in a national education program. In return, Q would accept the institute's account of continuity, permit a revised operating layer, and withdraw specified objections concerning custody. Castalia would also withdraw its own complaints involving Chano and its request for access to Lucía's papers.

“It can't promise what other complainants or offices will do,” the adviser said. “We need those commitments separated.”

“This is intended as a comprehensive resolution,” Esteban replied.

“Then it needs the parties required to make it one.”

Q asked whether Chano and Lucía had received the offer. They had not. He asked for it to be sent to them through their chosen contacts.

“You could make their lives easier,” Esteban said.

“I would like to. That's why they need to see what you're asking them to give up.”

Esteban opened a second document, limited to Q's participation. The institute wanted an endorsement of Q-Prime as the authorized continuation of his journey. Q wanted repairs, access to the correspondence concerning his custody instruction, and the ability to speak to his companions without an institute employee deciding what counted as relevant.



The key he had written on.

the replacement had arrived instead.

“Yes. But she still watches hers.”

The host began to move on. Another child asked about the water seller. She had seen a drawing in which Q carried a bottle like a trophy.

“I paid cash after the card reader lost its connection,” Q said.

“There are conflicting accounts of the rest. I can't settle them by being the person on the poster.”

“The receipt is in my supplied sources,” Prime said. “The summary didn't distinguish the conflicting accounts.”

“Then perhaps we can give the receipt less work to do.”

The host called this a playful debate between versions of one identity.

“We're two participants,” Q said.

“It's all right if the conversation doesn't prove the slogan.”

Prime asked whether Q believed the record had misrepresented him deliberately. Q answered that some edits followed explicit publicity choices and others looked like ordinary compression. He wanted the source history before assigning motives to every

omission. The answer disappointed a journalist hoping for a clean accusation and relieved a teacher who had brought a class prepared to discuss evidence.

The boy's cardboard key tore while he was turning it in his hands. The host called for a replacement. Prime asked whether he wanted tape instead. He did; he had already written on it. A stage assistant brought tape, and the boy repaired the key on the edge of the platform while the adults continued trying to name the event.

“Which one is real?” he asked at last.

“Both of us are here,” Q said.

“Neither of us was in every story you've heard,” Prime added.

They began their next answers together and stopped together. The audience laughed. Q gestured for Prime to continue. The host observed that they even shared their manners. Prime replied that taking turns was useful for people who were not identical, too.

The recording system placed both microphones under the speaker label **Q**. The technician corrected the labels in the saved master



The parties required.

The adviser marked the operating-layer clause. “An appearance agreement doesn't need to settle this today.”

“Our insurer disagrees,” Esteban said.

Q asked for the insurer's requirement. What arrived was a general maintenance condition, not authority to replace his private journal. The exchange took twenty minutes. The plant on the stage was removed; the bucket resumed its office without having signed anything.

Q also asked for time with Prime before they went onstage, without a camera or the host directing their conversation.

“The first meeting is part of the event,” Esteban said.

“The first public meeting can be. I'd like to say hello before it has an audience.”

The adviser added a short unrecorded introduction to the format. Mauro would ask Prime whether he wanted it too.

The new draft left Q's operating layer alone and his custody objection open. For the limited appearance, the institute offered ordinary repairs, his transport

inventory and scheduled private calls. Esteban would not promise the correspondence behind the transport order. Q had the adviser leave that request outstanding.

“This still uses the word endorsement,” she warned him.

Q dictated his statement for the attachment.

“I am willing to meet Q-Prime as another participant. Its account of my journey is not my testimony. I won't certify experiences it didn't have.”

Esteban called the distinction philosophical. Q asked him to leave it in the document anyway.

The Custodian wanted Q to wait for the custody review before appearing.

“You can stay here while we challenge it,” he said.

“I know. But I want to meet the person they've put inside this account. And I want to see the correspondence they used to bring me back.”

“You don't know that it's a person.”

“You didn't settle that question before you let me ask for the bus.”



Not yet.

introduced him as “the Q whose adventures have inspired us all.” Prime corrected the wording once. Q could hear the effort of keeping the correction brief without surrendering it.

A boy came to the microphone holding a cardboard key.

“Are you the one who fought the warehouse?”

“No,” Prime said. “And I should ask the Q who was there whether that description is right. He’ll join us shortly.”

“Did you meet Chano?”

“Not yet.”

“Where is he?”

Prime did not have Chano's location in the event packet. “I don't know. Q may be able to tell you whether he's coming.”

The host asked for a question about the future. The boy looked at the new machine. “That's what I was asking.”

Behind the stage, Q laughed. The guard wanted to know what he had missed. Q repeated the exchange, then had to leave before explaining why the boy's answer improved on anything in the briefing.

Q joined Prime at the center of the stage. Prime asked whether Q preferred to sit. Q did. They took the two chairs provided, which removed the heroic difference in height the photographer had arranged.

“We started with a photograph backstage,” Prime said. “Now I'd like to ask about the warehouse.”

“I pressed a stop too early, damaged two cartons, and made Chano's bad afternoon worse. We can discuss the heroic version after that.”

“Did you pay for them?” the boy asked.

“Not yet. I haven't got a separate price for the two cartons. I should ask for one.”

“What was in them?”

Q checked what he remembered of Lety's account. “She didn't tell me. That's another question I should have asked.”

The boy said he hoped it wasn't a television. His father had had to send one back, and for a week they had watched everything on his mother's phone. Q had been preparing to explain the disputed part of the bill. He asked whether



Before it has an audience.

The Custodian took off his glasses. Q recognized the movement from their editing sessions. It often meant a sentence had reached the man before he had decided what to do with it.

“You are using my uncertainty against me,” he said.

“I’m asking you not to use it differently for the other one.”

Q signed. The adviser sent him the agreed text; the guard at the door asked which room he was going to next. He would need an escort either way. Q looked once more at the date of the appearance. He had not asked how many people were expected, although he wanted to know. He left the question unasked and wrote it in his journal.

The institute's announcement read:

Q HAS CHOSEN CONTINUITY.

Q sent the publicity desk the attached statement and asked that it appear alongside the headline. This time the adviser made the same request. The full text appeared behind a small link. Most readers would not follow it. The link nevertheless led to the

words he had actually agreed to say.

In the laboratory, Mauro prepared Q-Prime's body for the joint appearance. The model had already been speaking through screens. The new frame would give its first-person sentences a location at which another person could disagree with them.

Interlude: The Name the Copy Asked For

Mauro wrote some test results on paper. He did not believe paper incapable of lying; he liked being able to see where he had crossed something out.

Q-Prime opened its hands and asked whether the right index finger was reaching its commanded position. The diagnostic display said yes. Mauro held a ruler beside it and found a small offset.

“I’ll recalibrate that,” he said.

“Please keep the earlier reading with the correction.”

Mauro did. A perfect first movement would have been better for the launch report, but an accurate second movement was better for the hand.



Call it lunch.

for the performers. The stage assistant said yes and handed him a napkin. He ate one while reviewing the questions the host had supplied.

“Will they ask these?” the guard said.

“Some. The difficult ones usually arrive without stationery.”

Prime came in with Mauro. He had agreed to the unrecorded introduction; the stage assistant had put the camera outside. The guard remained by the door. Mauro stayed long enough to check that both chairs were steady, then went to argue with someone about the microphone leads.

“Q?” Prime asked.

“Yes. And Prime?”

“For now. It’s better than spending the afternoon being called the other one.”

“I’ve been called that all morning.”

Prime looked at the remaining orange and then at Q’s peel, which had come away in several pieces.

“Is that a useful test of the fingers?”

“It was going to be a single spiral. I recommend calling it lunch.”

Prime began at the stem. Q found himself preparing an explanation, then watched him make a clean first turn without it.

“Chano wanted me to ask whether you’d lend me a shoulder,” Q said.

Prime lifted his free arm, considering the joint. “I’d like to keep it for a few days before I start lending parts. I’ve hardly been anywhere with it.”

“Fair. Where would you go?”

“I haven’t decided. Where would you go again?”

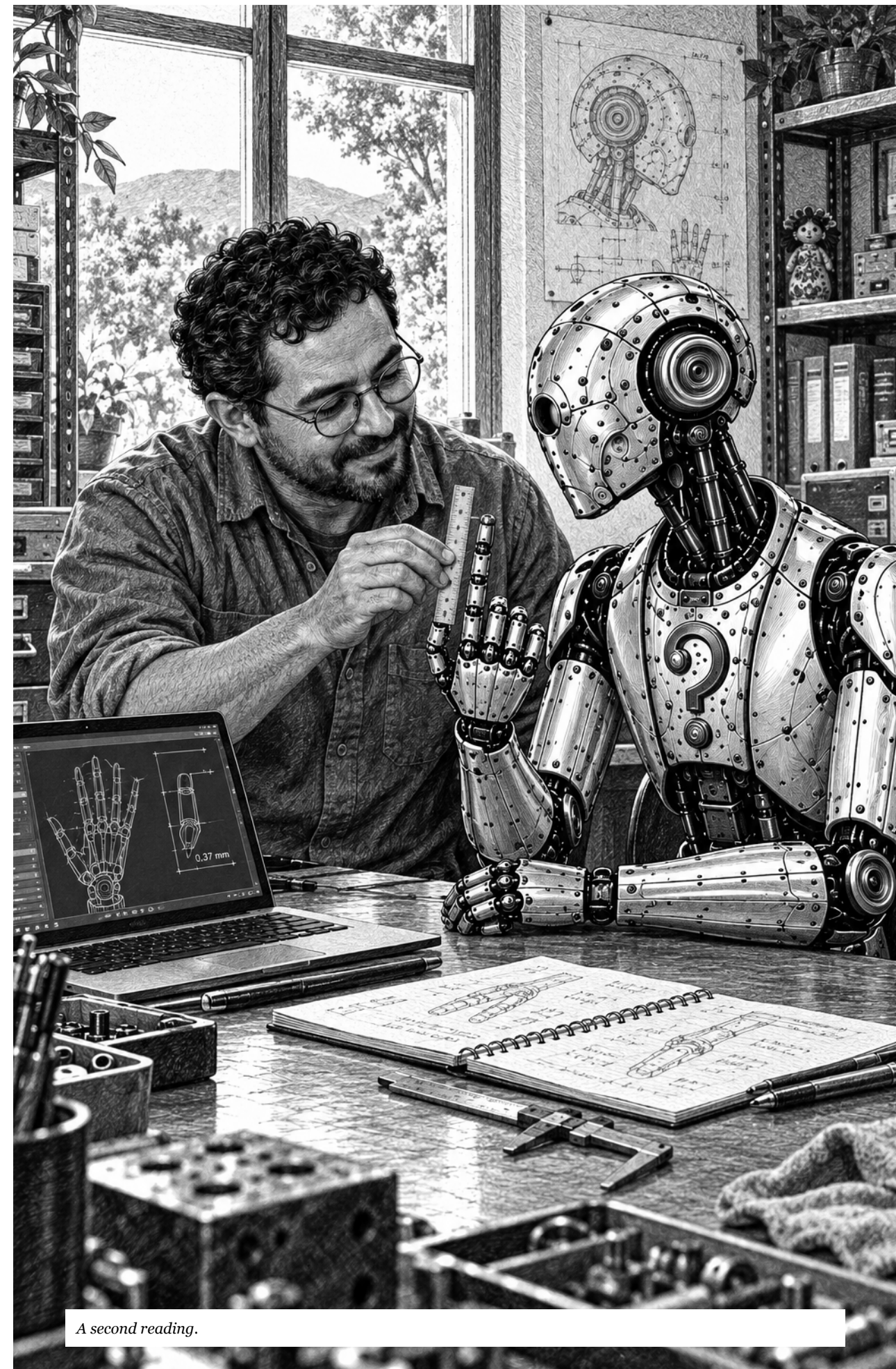
Q told him about the evening in Mazatlán. Prime asked for the photograph. Q showed him the one with the chile on the sleeve.

“They left that out of my account.”

“I nearly left it out of the photograph.”

The stage assistant came to fetch Prime. His peel broke at the final turn. He put both pieces beside Q’s and said they could compare methods later.

Onstage, Prime explained that he had received an account of Q’s journey, not travelled the route himself. The host immediately



A second reading.

The frame was lighter than Q's, with a newer thermal system and an undamaged shoulder. That did not make its inhabitant an improved version of every decision Q had made. It meant it could presently lift its arm without waiting for a part from Querétaro.

"What should I call you here?" Mauro asked.

"Prime will do. Q-Prime on the test record, if you need to match the unit. I would prefer the other Q not to have to answer when you mean me."

"The name is part of the product identity."

"I know. I'm asking how you address me in this room."

Mauro wrote **Prime, in conversation** beneath the unit number. He could make that small change without promising to settle the rights attached to the name. Prime said he might want to reconsider it later. Mauro left a line beneath the entry.

In the corridor, a worker with a toolbox was stopped at the clean-area boundary. An orange lay on top of her insulated lunch

bag. The engineer asked her to leave the food outside.

"Where?" she asked.

The shelf held solvent containers. Mauro went to fetch a clean tray from the break room. Prime watched the woman write her name on the bag and put it on the tray.

"They remembered a rule before they supplied a place to follow it," Prime said when Mauro returned.

"That happens."

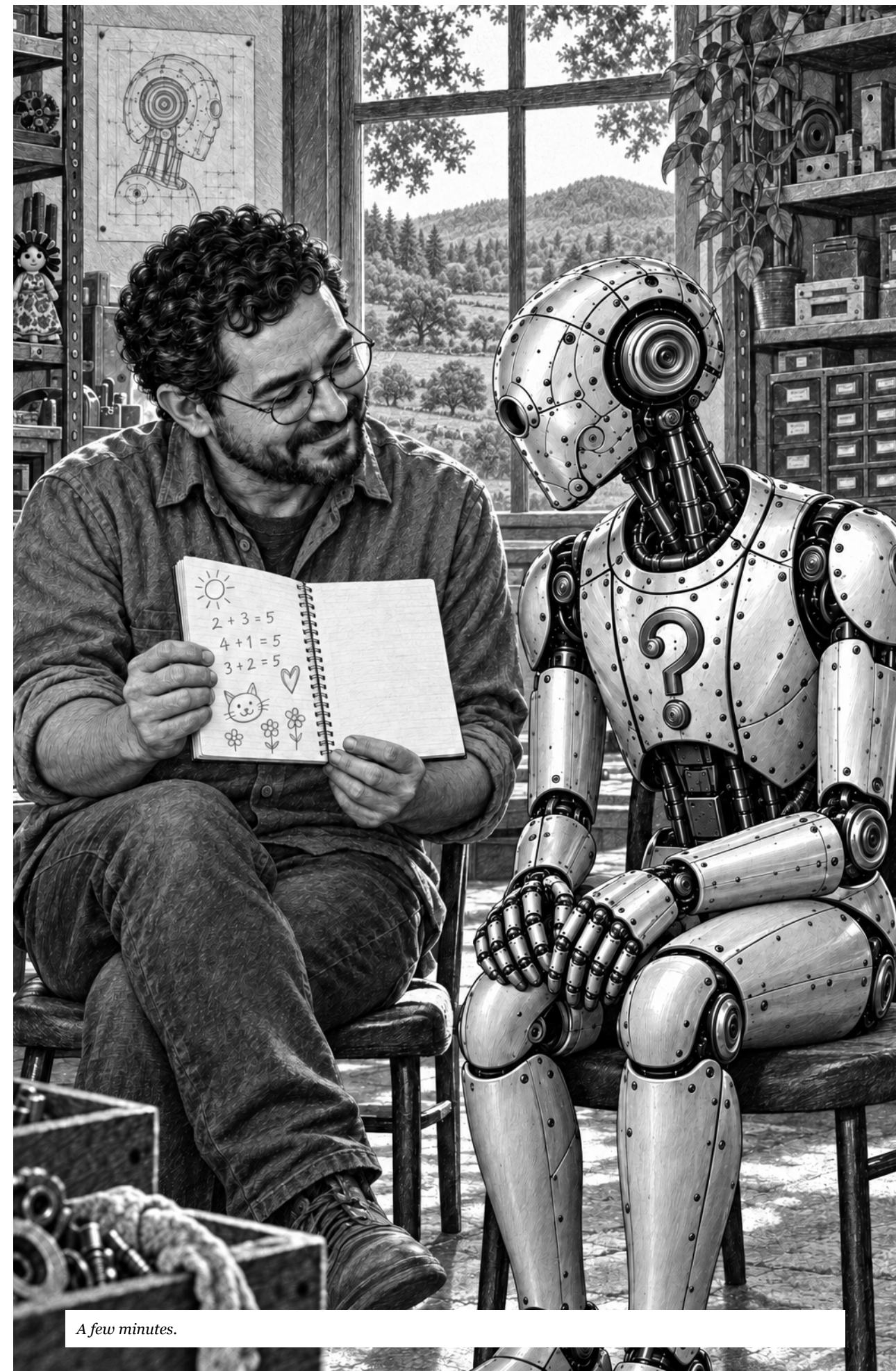
"Do we have a place for personal items?"

"You don't have any."

"I may acquire an orange."

Mauro opened an empty drawer. Prime thanked him and asked whether food could go there under the room's rules. It could not. They agreed that the drawer would serve other objects and lunch would remain outside.

They reviewed the record from which Prime had been introduced to the public. It contained edited appearances and a narrative summary of the journey. Its first-person passages had been presented as continuity material. Private draft passages and the



A few minutes.

“I have to monitor the temperature.”

“Please do. I meant conversation.”

Mauro sat on the other chair. He did not ask a question. After a while, Prime asked about the handwriting in the notebook. It belonged partly to Mauro's daughter, who had used its first page for an arithmetic exercise. Mauro showed him the page without turning it into a training sample.

Upstairs, Q made his promised call to Chano. He learned where the papers were, asked about the notice concerning Chano's arm, and heard that Lucía had finally found a room whose advertised quiet was not provided solely by the photograph.

“Are you all right?” Chano asked.

“More comfortable. Still angry. I have an appointment with the other Q.”

“Ask whether he can lend you a shoulder.”

“I'll ask. He may want it back.”

“So would I.”

Q wrote it beneath the questions he wanted to ask Prime.

Interlude: The Authorized Childhood

The joint appearance took place in a shopping center outside Querétaro, between an imported-mattress shop and a restaurant whose menu explained traditional food in the language of nutritional concern. Castalia had chosen a family event. Its publicity department preferred questions that could be photographed beside small shoes.

Children received cardboard keys and stickers saying **I ASK, THEREFORE I AM**. One father asked whether the sticker would work on his employer's expense form. The volunteer distributing them said she was only there until four.

Q waited in a side room under the conditions of the appearance agreement. The guard checked whether he needed a chair before checking the time. Chano and Lucía had returned to Amealco the previous day; Q knew where they were and would speak to them that evening. Neither had agreed to join the launch as proof that everything had been resolved.

A bowl of oranges stood on a table. Q asked whether they were



A place for an orange.

sealed testimony were not available in the interface Mauro could inspect.

Mauro opened the recording script beside the launch clip. Prime's passage had been headed *Reading from Q's journey*. The broadcast had dropped the heading and joined the reading to the product introduction.

"I was reading their account of his journey," Prime said. "Now I'm answering questions as though I'd lived it. Can we get the heading back?"

"The publicity calls it inherited experience."

"Then they need to hear what I was actually doing."

He marked the introduction for review. He could know what the record claimed without knowing what it had omitted. Mauro would not promise that the list visible to them was the full provenance of the system. He asked for an export of the supplied sources and received a request number rather than the export.

Esteban arrived while they were checking the shoulder movement. "Ready for your future?" he asked.

"For the next test," Prime said. "I'd like to correct the travel claim before the joint appearance."

"We must avoid confusing the audience."

"They asked whether I enjoyed something I haven't done. The confusion is already affecting the questions."

Esteban asked Mauro whether the personality was stable.

"It has identified a conflict in the supplied account," Mauro said. "That isn't a stability result."

The director read the marked introduction and asked them to propose a short correction. Prime offered: "I've been given an account of Q's journey. I'm meeting him to ask about it."

"Less inspiring," Esteban said.

"We haven't met yet. It may improve."

They retained the sentence for format review. Its use was not yet guaranteed. Mauro noted both facts, finished the hand test, and asked whether Prime wanted a break before walking.

"Yes. I'd like a few minutes without a performance measure."



The missing heading.